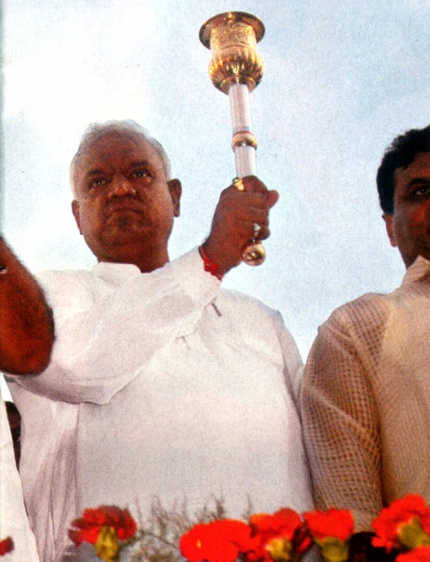


SHOW OF STRENGTH: Modi (centre) with his supporters



GROUND



Photographs by SHAILESH RAVAL

aspirations in the name of public interest: in this instance, the plight of farmers under the Modi regime. They allege that the state Government has reduced power supply to the farmers from 43 to 27 per cent creating great hardships for them in extracting ground water for irrigation purposes while giving abundant power to the industries.

Another charge harps on the tough measures that the Government has taken to curb power theft. Jhadaphia says the Government has made criminal laws applicable to power theft in the farming sector and has sent 2,000 farmers to jail in two years. "You can't treat farmers as criminals. Modi's is a government of rich businessmen and not of farmers and the poor," he says. Minister of State for Power Saurabh Patel however, dubs this as nothing but white lies. "The prosecution of the farmers caught in power theft has not even begun. So how can they be jailed? Plus, the application of criminal law in power theft in the farming sector has been introduced by the Centre. The farmers have, in fact, been beneficiaries of our power policies," he says.

According to the state's Home Minister Amit Shah, the charge that farmers are getting less power is patently false. "On the contrary," he says, "the farmers simply don't need huge amounts of electricity to draw ground water since enough surface water is available for irrigation purposes due to the Narmada project and successive good monsoons." The biggest evidence of this is the fact that crop production in Gujarat has gone up immensely in the past five years and the state's cultivation area has increased greatly too, he argues, saying these facts run totally contrary to the rebels' charges.

One of the reasons for the disgruntlement of the rebels seems to be their inability to pursue their personal agenda. At least two MLAs turned against Modi because of his Government's refusal to protect large

chunks of land, owned by them, from being swallowed by town planning schemes in south Gujarat. However, what has put off most of them is the chief minister's alleged high-handed attitude and obstinacy. Dissident MLA Dhiru Gajera says, "Modi is acting like Duryodhana and his story has to end like it did in Mahabharata. He is unleashing a Hitler raj and has damaged Gujarat's pride like nobody else has." Fumes Soma Ganda Patel, BJP MP, "Modi is a history-sheeter. More than 50 MLAs are itching to revolt against him." Even Keshubhai doesn't spare him and says, "Gujarat is virtually under a dictatorship."

And as the tirade continued, the air has been abuzz with questions: will Modi be able to steady his rocking boat? Will he be able to surmount this

By successfully wooing three Congress MLAs, Modi has delivered a blow—both to the Congress and to the rebel camp.

challenge and overcome the anti-incumbency factor when the Gujarati as well as the English media has been cutting in its criticism of him? And as if to give a befitting reply to those baiting him, Modi has been successful in bringing three Congress MLAs to the BJP fold, delivering a

blow—both to the Congress and to the dissident camp.

This is not all. Analysts believe that the rebels may not be in a very good position to draw votes since a majority of them are Patels and given the anti-Patel caste equations in Saurashtra and north Gujarat, this could well prove counter-productive for the dissidents since it could spur an anti-Patel wave in Modi's favour. Moreover, if the public response is anything to go by, the chief minister seems to be in his element. His public meetings in Ahmedabad, Mehsana and Billimora drew huge crowds. What came as a shot in his arm was the presence of two of the three ex-Congress MLAs, Manish Giletwala and Shankar Varli, at the Billimora rally.

As the parties gear up for the Assembly elections, Modi may well be facing his sternest test ever. This time, he has to fight not just the Opposition Congress but also the enemy within. ■